and so on) in UP.[18] The Yadavs, dominant under SP, make up only a small share (8.7 per cent) of the total population of UP[19] but had the bulk of the power during SP's regime. Similarly, UP's SC population officially consists of sixty-six castes.[20] Jatavs, who make up 54.2 per cent of UP's Dalits have always been the dominant caste in BSP. Not so much the other Dalit castes: Pasis, who make up the next 15.9 per cent of Dalits, followed by Dhobis, Koris, Valmikis, Khatiks and so on.[21] The BJP, after 2013, focused specifically on these non-Yadav OBCs and non-Jatav SCs. The key thing with some of the smaller castes is that, while they may be small in numbers, many of them are heavily concentrated in specific constituencies, which make them pivotal in electoral contests.

Three examples showcase the kind of political methods and symbols with which the BJP wooed the smaller and relatively ignored castes. Rajbhars (OBCs) account for a very small sliver of UP's population (an estimated 2.6 per cent)[22] but the party wooed them aggressively. Prime Minister Modi, as an example of this outreach, travelled to Ghazipur in December 2018 to launch a commemorative stamp on Raja Suheldev, an eleventh-century king of Shravasti, said to be both a Rajbhar and a Pasi icon, who many believe led some of the local resistance against the forces of the Afghan invader Mahmud of Ghazni centuries ago.[23] The BJP also joined hands with the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party. Its leader Om Prakash Rajbhar became a cabinet minister for backward classes in Yogi Adityanath's government, though the two allies continually had public spats until he left the alliance in May 2019.

Similarly, Nishads (OBCs) are estimated to make up 12 per cent of UP's population but are spread across the Ganga riverbank and comprise several boatmen sub-castes like Manjhis, Kewats, Binds and Mallahs. In May 2019, Amit Shah addressed several rallies in constituencies where Nishads form a sizeable chunk of voters. 'A grand memorial for Nishadraj worth Rs 34 crore will be built at Shringverpur,' promised the BJP president. In the epic Ramayana, a Nishad king had ferried Ram, Lakshman and Sita across the Sarayu river when they went into exile. Just as Yogi Adityanath had earlier promised a huge statue of Ram in Ayodhya as part of the BJP's